VON ZAROVICH ESTATE / STATION 4

The Mimic Menagerie

Four arches. Four keys. An uncomfortable silence.

The door seals behind you with a soft, final click. Dust and old lamp oil hang in the air. The room is round, its walls disappearing upward into purple-lit shadow.

Four stone arches stand along the far wall, numbered I, II, III, and IV in tarnished brass. Beneath each arch, a silver key with a wolf-shaped crest rests on a plain stone pedestal. The keys look exactly alike. So do the waiting pedestals.

A stone table stands back from the arches. Four wands rest in carved cradles: one shines with a sunlike crystal, one curls around a little serpent skull, one gleams green, and one ends in a ghostly sculpted hand. Their labels read Bright Light, Poison, Acid, and Mage Hand.

Brass studs form a line across the flagstones between the table and the arches. Along the walls, torch flames lean and straighten though you feel no breeze.

Nothing leaps out. Nothing growls. Nothing conveniently explains itself. The four silver keys simply wait, as if they have all the time in the world.

Behind you, the door handle refuses to turn.

What do you do? Talk with your partner. Tell the DM what you want to examine or try. Your character sheet may give you ideas.

The Mimic Menagerie

Cut out the 5 × 7 inch card.

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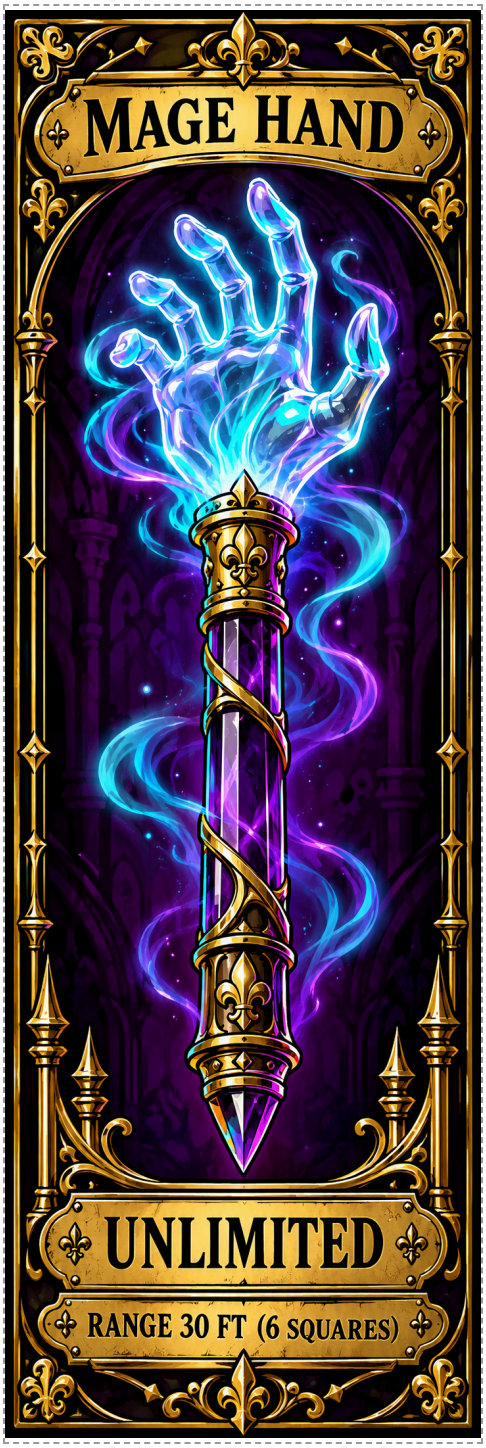
Magical Testing Wands

Bookmark cards: 2.5 × 7.5 inches, preserving the generated proportions.

Magical Testing Wands



Bookmark cards: 2.5 × 7.5 inches, preserving the generated proportions.

Table Tokens

Removable charge tokens

Place each token on its wand's socket. Hand the token to the DM when used.

Brass stud line — table marker

TESTING SIDE • • • • • • • • • • • • • • • • • • ALCOVES

Investigation notes

Alcove	What we tested	What happened
I		
II		
III		
IV		

DM-held reveals — keep hidden until earned

Place each on the tested alcove only after its reveal. No card has a fixed alcove number.

Mimic standee

Cut the mimic silhouette and leave its base tab. Use a standee clip, or fold the tab and tape to a small cardstock foot.

Menagerie Crest #4 — success only

DM-held plaque — Clue 3 only

Keep behind the screen until the wand-rack search earns it, or the 8–9 minute nudge.

Assembly

Cut the 6 × 4 inch plaque apart from these instructions. Print single-sided; do not put a solution on the back.

DM ONLY — Menagerie control sheet

Starting layout: _____ Current: _____ Pair: _____

Layout	Alcove I	Alcove II	Alcove III	Alcove IV
A (book)	Illusion	Mimic	Construct	Real
B	Real	Construct	Illusion	Mimic
C	Construct	Real	Mimic	Illusion
D	Mimic	Illusion	Real	Construct

Wand reactions

Wand → / Content ↓	Bright Light	Poison (1 charge)	Acid (1 charge)	Mage Hand (lifts)
Illusion	Shadow stays frozen. Reveal.	"The mist drifts straight through the key." Reveal.	"The acid passes through and hisses on the wall behind." Reveal.	Gong, vapour. Reset.
Mimic	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	Gags and slumps. Reveal.	"The acid splashes over the key and hisses on the pedestal. The key looks unharmed."	Bites the hand, lunges. Reset.
Construct	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	"The mist beads on the metal and drifts away."	Casing melts, fuse dies. Reveal (disarmed).	Armed: explodes and resets. After Acid: harmless scrap; no reset, not the real key.
Real key	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	"The mist beads on the metal and drifts away."	"The acid splashes over the key and hisses on the pedestal. The key looks unharmed."	Success.

Reset

Advance A → B → C → D → A. Remove all reveal cards, return both charge tokens, and announce that the contents have moved. Keep alcove cards in place.

Hazards

Mimic: AC 12, HP 15, +5 bite; 1d8+2 piercing +2 acid (average 6 piercing). Mage Hand absorbs the bite. Murray can restrain it for 2 rounds. Armed construct: DC 12 Dex, 2d4 damage, half on success. Acid disarms it: lifting is safe and the door rejects the scrap without a reset. A reset rearms it. Illusion: gong, no damage. Retrieving an illusion, mimic or armed construct resets.

DM ONLY — Coaching & clue timing

Start neutrally

Four identical silver wolf-crest keys wait under arches. Four wands rest on a table. Describe each key the same way. Do not expose the reveal cards, plaque or crest.

2–3 minutes: orientation

“What happened to the last people here?” Describe scorches, tooth gouges and sticky residue beyond the brass studs, spread across all four alcoves. Point out the two single charge sockets.

5–6 minutes: character hook

“Scooby, anything on your sheet that a snack helps with?” Roll d20 +14 vs DC 17 (1–2 fail). On success: alive identifies the current mimic; fake identifies the current illusion. On failure: surge spent, no location or false clue, no reset; continue with wands or Murray’s lore. Neither identifies the real key. Use the current layout.

8–9 minutes: logic clue

Reveal the plaque after the rack search, or when dust is smeared away. Do not assign its verses to alcove numbers.

11 minutes, or reset after 10: emergency

Prompt Murray to tap with his bandage whip. Mimic: wet snore. Construct: ticking. Illusion: passes through key. Real: hollow brass bell. Give locations from the current layout. Accept a player’s clever early tap.

13–15 minutes

At 13 minutes the real key glows if needed. Finish by 15 minutes with a funny cost. Do not stall an early solve.

Keep tests fair

Use the reaction table’s identical words for identical outcomes. A plain result still conveys evidence. Collect Poison/Acid tokens before resolving the test. A reset clears every previous observation.

Source: Stations/Station_4_Mimic_Menagerie_Wands_and_Keys.md. This is a quick reference; use the station sheet for full adjudication.

STATION 4 HELPER GM — THE MIMIC MENAGERIE (WANDS & KEYS)

Pair: Scooby-Doo (Barbarian) & Murray Mummy (Druid) · **Goal:** test four identical keys with four wands and lift the real one with Mage Hand → **Crest #4 + Evidence Card E4**. **Target:** 10–15 min. Full rules: `Stations/Station_4_Mimic_Menagerie_Wands_and_Keys.md`.

Before the players arrive

- Four **identical** alcove cards, Alcove I–IV. Four wand cards; a **purple bead on Poison** and a **green bead on Acid** (one charge each).
- Reveal tiles (Illusion Dispelled, Mimic, Disarmed Construct) face down in your box. The Menagerie plaque (Envelope 3) face down under the wand rack.
- Shuffle Tracker on your clipboard with a **paperclip on the starting layout**. **A real snack for Scooby; check allergies.** Phone timer.

Your special job: the shuffle and the wands

- **Collect the bead before narrating.** The moment a player fires Poison or Acid, hold out your hand for the bead.
- **Read the matrix wording exactly.** Identical outcomes get identical words, so plain results are clues too.
- **A wrong key lifted** (by hand, mage hand, whip, or a thrown object) triggers that alcove, then **reset**: read the reset line, move the paperclip **A → B → C → D → A**, clear all reveal tiles, return both beads.

> Reset line: "With a grinding roar, the four arches spin like a roulette wheel and lock back into place. Whatever you learned, it's scrambled now. Two fresh gems click into the wand cradles."

Layout	Alcove I	Alcove II	Alcove III	Alcove IV
A	Illusion	Mimic	Construct	**Real**
B	**Real**	Construct	Illusion	Mimic
C	Construct	**Real**	Mimic	Illusion
D	Mimic	Illusion	**Real**	Construct

Wand reaction matrix (say these words exactly)

Content	Bright Light	Poison (1 charge)	Acid (1 charge)	Mage Hand (lifts)
Illusion	Shadow stays frozen. **Reveal.**	"The mist drifts straight *through* the key." **Reveal.**	"The acid passes through and hisses on the wall behind." **Reveal.**	Gong, cold vapour. **Reset.**
Mimic	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	Gags and slumps into a grey blob. **Reveal.**	"The acid splashes over the key and hisses on the pedestal. The key looks unharmed."	Bites, lunges. **Reset.**
Construct	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	"The mist beads on the metal and drifts away."	Casing melts, fuse dies. **Reveal (disarmed).**	Armed: explodes, **reset**. After Acid: harmless scrap; no reset, not the real key.
Real key	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	"The mist beads on the metal and drifts away."	"The acid splashes over the key and hisses on the pedestal. The key looks unharmed."	**Success!**

STATION 4 HELPER GM — RUNNING THE ROOM

Station clock

Time	Do this
0:00	Read the Player Introduction aloud. Start the timer.
2:00–3:00	**Envelope 1** when they look around, or someone reaches for a key with no plan.
5:00–6:00	**Envelope 2**: toss Scooby a real snack if he hasn't used Snack Surge.
8:00–9:00	**Envelope 3** on a wand-rack search (Investigation DC 10), or reveal it at 9:00.
11:00	Stuck, or a reset after 10:00: **Envelope 4**.
13:00	Not solved: the real key starts to glow faintly.
15:00	Lead GM's bell = hard stop. Then **Envelope 5** and send them to the Gate.

Hazards (scaled for teens)

- **Mimic** (AC 12, 15 HP): one bite at whoever disturbed it, +5 to hit, **1d8+2 piercing + 2 acid** (it crunches a mage hand instead and gets no bite). Then Murray's Shuffle and Scooby's bites finish it, then **reset**.
- **After Acid:** construct is harmless, including Mage Hand; door rejects it without a reset. A room reset rearms it.
- **Armed construct:** everyone within 30 ft makes a **DC 12 Dex save, 2d4** damage, half on a save. Then **reset**.
- **Illusion:** a gong, no damage. **Reset.**

Character rulings

- **Scooby, Scooby Snack Surge** (needs a real snack): +14 Perception vs **DC 17** (1–2 fail; 3–20 succeed). Failed sniff: surge spent, no location/false clue, no reset. Scooby asks **one** question: *"alive?"* (finds the mimic) or *"fake?"* (finds the illusion). After a reset, only DC 15 without a surge, unless you give a mercy snack.
- **Murray, Sandstorm Shuffle** (Action): automatically restrains the mimic for 2 rounds.
- **Murray, Nature DC 10:** *"Mimics digest with acid. Acid won't bother one, but poison makes them gag."*
- **Murray, Bandage Whip** (reach 2 squares): lifting a key counts as Mage Hand. **Tapping a pedestal** (not the key) is safe and gives that alcove's Envelope 4 sound.

Nudges (questions only)

- About to grab a key: *"Does anything here tell you what happened to the last people?"*
- Zapping at random: *"What question does each wand answer?"*
- Forgot the charges: *"Anything printed on the wand cards you haven't used?"*
- Ignoring Scooby: *"Scooby, your stomach just growled."*
- Two keys left, no charges: *"Anything either of you can do that isn't a wand?"*

Don't

- Don't hint at any alcove, and keep a straight face when they point at the real one.
- Don't put a reveal tile or the mimic standee out until it's earned.
- Don't call them "the mimic wand" or "the bomb wand"; use the wand names.

Reward (Envelope 5)

Hand over **Crest #4** and **Evidence Card E4**: *"Take these to the Grand Gate!"*

STATION 4 — ENVELOPE LABELS

ENVELOPE 1 · LOOK AROUND

Station 4 · Menagerie. Open at **2–3 min**, or when someone reaches for a key with no plan.

ENVELOPE 2 · YOUR SHEET

Station 4 · Menagerie. Open on **Scooby Snack Surge** (5–6 min). Bring a real snack!

ENVELOPE 3 · THE RULE

Station 4 · Menagerie. Open on a wand-rack search (DC 10), or at **9:00**.

ENVELOPE 4 · SEALED: EMERGENCY

Station 4 · Menagerie. **Helper only.** At 11:00 if stuck, or after a reset past 10:00.

ENVELOPE 5 · REWARD

Station 4 · Menagerie. Open on solve: **Crest #4 + Evidence Card E4**.

ENVELOPE CONTENTS

ENVELOPE 1 · THE SCORCHED FLOOR (READ ALOUD)

> Just past the line of brass studs, the floor is scorched in a black fan shape: deep tooth gouges in the flagstones and a dried, sticky puddle. Nothing like that is on your side of the line. The wand cradles are worn smooth. Two of them have a single socket where a charge-gem sits.

ENVELOPE 2 · SCOOBY SNACK SURGE (READ ALOUD)

Roll d20 +14 vs DC 17 first. On success, fill in the alcove from the current layout. On failure: "The snack crumbs and old smells muddle your nose. You cannot isolate an alcove." Surge spent; no reset.

> "alive?" → Scooby's snout twitches into overdrive. Alcove ___ smells like a wet swamp monster that just ate a meatloaf. Something in there is breathing.
> "fake?" → Alcove ___ smells of... nothing at all. Not metal, not dust. It's like the key isn't there.

ENVELOPE 3 · THE MENAGERIE PLAQUE

Hand this to the players.

> Four keys wait, and three are lies.
> What casts no true shadow, the sun will expose;
> What lives will choke where the venom blows;
> What ticks, the acid melts from within;
> One breath, one drop: spend them, then win.
> Touch none with your hand. Let the ghost hand begin.

ENVELOPE 4 · MURRAY'S BANDAGE TAP (READ ALOUD)

Prompt: "Murray, your Bandage Whip reaches 2 squares. Want to tap the pedestals, without touching the keys?" Fill in from the current layout.

> Tap... Alcove ___ lets out an irritated, wet snore.
> Tap... Alcove ___ gives a faint clockwork tick-tick-tick. Tap... the whip passes straight through the key in Alcove ___. Tap... Alcove ___ rings like a pure, hollow brass bell.

ENVELOPE 5 · EVIDENCE CARD E4: THE MIMIC'S SNACK

Goes in with Crest #4.

> Stuck between the mimic's needle teeth: a tuft of hair stained bright **purple**.